‘*Swadeshi Steam* is a superb book by one of our finest historians. Written with panache and grounded in painstaking research in Tamil sources, A.R. Venkatachalapathy’s riveting account of V.O. Chidambaram Pillai’s anti-colonial shipping line sheds new light on how commerce and politics combined in the struggle for a free India’—Sunil Amrith, MacArthur Prize Fellow

‘*Swadeshi Steam* is an intricately crafted and captivating story about a small-town pleader’s struggles to build up a steamship company—one capable of competing with the British maritime monopoly. It narrates his difficult journey from “setting sail” to “running aground”. The important microhistory uncovers and weaves together many other little-known or unknown histories: Tamil anti-colonial nationalism in the Madras Presidency, life in the port town of Tuticorin, shipping and maritime commerce, and careers of business establishments among several other themes. The masterly narrative is as vivid as it is richly textured. It is a pleasure to read’—Tanika Sarkar, retired professor, modern history, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Delhi